

D668

Elementary Literacy Curriculum

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A third grader answers questions well when a story is read aloud to him but understands little when he reads the same story himself. He loves drawing dinosaurs and sits near the reading corner. According to the Simple View of Reading, what is the most likely area of need?

- A. More comprehension strategy lessons
- B. Language comprehension
- C. Decoding (word recognition)
- D. Interest, since he prefers dinosaurs

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A fourth grader decodes grade-level text accurately and quickly but cannot explain what the passage meant, even when it is read aloud to her. Which area should instruction target?

- A. Reading speed.
- B. Language comprehension: vocabulary, background knowledge, and language structures.
- C. Nothing, since accurate decoding always means comprehension.
- D. Phonics and decoding drills.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A literacy coach is sorting a grade-level team's goals by strands of Scarborough's Reading Rope. One goal is building students' knowledge of ecosystems before reading a science text. The team meets in the library, and the school is 50 years old. Which strand does this goal support?

- A. Background knowledge, in the language comprehension strands
- B. Sight recognition
- C. Decoding, in the word recognition strands
- D. Phonological awareness

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A kindergarten teacher says a word aloud, “ship,” and students clap once for each sound they hear. No letters are shown. The class has a pet hamster and meets in the morning. What type of activity is this?

- A. Syllable awareness
- B. Phonics
- C. Fluency practice
- D. Phonemic awareness (phoneme segmentation)

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity is phonics rather than phonological awareness?

- A. Students build “map” with letter tiles, then change one tile to make “mop.”
- B. Students say “cat” without the /k/ sound.
- C. Students clap the syllables in “banana.”
- D. Students name words that rhyme with “sun.”

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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6.

An English learner who arrived 18 months ago chats easily with classmates and loves soccer at recess. Her family recently moved to a larger apartment. In science, she struggles to understand the textbook. What best explains this?

- A. She likely has a learning disability since her speaking is fluent.
- B. She is not trying because she can chat easily.
- C. Conversational English can develop in 1-3 years, while academic English often takes 5-7 years.
- D. The move to a new apartment distracted her.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants to support an English learner who is fluent socially but struggles with academic text. Which support targets the gap?

- A.** More free conversation time with peers.
- B.** Preteach academic vocabulary and sentence frames for the lesson's content.
- C.** Remove her from science until her English improves.
- D.** Wait, since academic language always develops on its own.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A second grader reads a passage aloud for 2 minutes during a benchmark check. He reads 212 words with 12 errors. The passage is about a lighthouse, and he wears a red jacket. What are his words correct per minute (WCPM)?

- A.** 106
- B.** 100
- C.** 94
- D.** 200

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student reads 150 words in one minute with 15 errors. What is her accuracy rate?

- A.** 90%
- B.** 100%, since she finished the passage
- C.** 135%
- D.** 10%

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A teacher is choosing a novel for a fourth-grade class. The book's readability score falls in the grade-4 band, and the cover won a design award. What else should she consider before choosing it?

- A.** The cover design award.
- B.** Nothing more; the readability score settles it.
- C.** Only the book's length.
- D.** Qualitative features, like structure and themes, and her students' knowledge and the task.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A school is reviewing a K-2 reading program. Its word-reading prompts say, “Look at the picture and think what would make sense.” The program has colorful books and a free app. Why is this a concern under the science of reading?

- A.** It lacks comprehension questions.
- B.** The books are too colorful.
- C.** It is not a concern; using pictures is always the best word strategy.
- D.** It teaches students to guess words from cues instead of decoding the letters, which weakens orthographic mapping.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A fifth grader's draft of a letter to the principal asking for a school garden lists ideas without reasons. The student used a purple pen and wrote three pages. What is the best revision feedback?

- A.** Cut it to one page.
- B.** Fix spelling and capitalization first.
- C.** Add reasons and evidence the principal would care about to support each idea.
- D.** Rewrite it in pencil so it looks neater.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A third grader answers questions well when a story is read aloud to him but understands little when he reads the same story himself. ~~He loves drawing dinosaurs and sits near the reading corner.~~ According to the Simple View of Reading, what is the most likely area of need?

Target word: which component is weak **Decides:** Listening comprehension is strong; reading alone is weak.

A	Adjacent category	Strategies do not fix a decoding gap.
B	Inverted operation	His listening comprehension is strong.
C	Correct	Strong language comprehension plus weak reading comprehension points to decoding.
D	Camouflage	Interest does not explain the listening vs. reading gap.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

A fourth grader decodes grade-level text accurately and quickly but cannot explain what the passage meant, even when it is read aloud to her. Which area should instruction target?

Target word: reverse: other component weak **Decides:** Decoding is strong; listening comprehension is weak.

A	Adjacent category	Rate is not the problem.
B	Correct	Comprehension is low even when decoding is removed.
C	Absolute language	Decoding is necessary but not sufficient.
D	Inverted operation	Decoding is already strong.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A literacy coach is sorting a grade-level team's goals by strands of Scarborough's Reading Rope. One goal is building students' knowledge of ecosystems before reading a science text. ~~The team meets in the library, and the school is 50 years old.~~ Which strand does this goal support?

Target word: classify into a strand **Decides:** Knowledge of the topic is background knowledge.

A	Correct	Topic knowledge is a language comprehension strand.
B	Dropped element	A word recognition strand; drops the content focus.
C	Confusion set	Decoding is sounding out print.
D	Adjacent category	Oral sound work, a word recognition strand.

4. Answer D Concept 3

A kindergarten teacher says a word aloud, "ship," and students clap once for each sound they hear. No letters are shown. ~~The class has a pet hamster and meets in the morning.~~ What type of activity is this?

Target word: classify the activity **Decides:** Oral, individual sounds, no print.

A	Adjacent category	They count sounds, not syllables.
B	Confusion set	Phonics connects sounds to letters; no letters are used.
C	Dropped element	No connected text is read.
D	Correct	Oral work with individual phonemes.

5. Answer A Concept 3 • transfer

Which activity is phonics rather than phonological awareness?

Target word: reverse: find the phonics task **Decides:** Phonics uses letters.

A	Correct	Linking sounds to letters is phonics.
B	Inverted operation	Oral phoneme deletion.
C	Confusion set	Oral syllable work.
D	Adjacent category	Oral rhyming.

6. Answer C Concept 4

An English learner who arrived 18 months ago chats easily with classmates ~~and loves soccer at recess. Her family recently moved to a larger apartment.~~ In science, she struggles to understand the textbook. What best explains this?

Target word: BICS vs. CALP **Decides:** Social language develops faster than academic language.

A	Adjacent category	Normal second-language development, not evidence of a disability.
B	Inverted operation	Reads social fluency as full proficiency.
C	Correct	BICS vs. CALP timelines.
D	Camouflage	Housing does not explain the academic language gap.

7. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

A teacher wants to support an English learner who is fluent socially but struggles with academic text. Which support targets the gap?

Target word: reverse: support for CALP **Decides:** Academic language needs explicit support.

A	Confusion set	Builds social language she already has.
B	Correct	Builds academic language directly.
C	Inverted operation	Withholds content and academic language exposure.
D	Absolute language	It benefits from explicit support.

8. Answer B Concept 5

A second grader reads a passage aloud for 2 minutes during a benchmark check. He reads 212 words with 12 errors. ~~The passage is about a lighthouse, and he wears a red jacket.~~ What are his words correct per minute (WCPM)?

Target word: compute WCPM **Decides:** $(212 - 12) \div 2$.

A	Dropped element	$212 \div 2$ drops the errors.
B	Correct	$200 \text{ correct words} \div 2 \text{ minutes} = 100$.
C	Confusion set	That is roughly accuracy percent ($200 \div 212 \approx 94\%$), not WCPM.
D	Wrong stem number	Correct words over 2 minutes, not per minute.

9. Answer A Concept 5 · transfer

A student reads 150 words in one minute with 15 errors. What is her accuracy rate?

Target word: solve for accuracy instead of rate **Decides:** $(150 - 15) \div 150$.

A	Correct	$135 \div 150 = 0.90$.
B	Absolute language	Finishing is not accuracy.
C	Wrong stem number	Uses the WCPM number as a percent.
D	Inverted operation	That is the error rate.

10. Answer D Concept 6

A teacher is choosing a novel for a fourth-grade class. The book's readability score falls in the grade-4 band, ~~and the cover won a design award~~. What else should she consider before choosing it?

Target word: complete text complexity judgment **Decides:** Quantitative is only one of three parts.

A	Camouflage	Awards for design do not measure complexity.
B	Absolute language	A number misses meaning, structure, and fit.
C	Dropped element	Length is one quantitative feature; drops the other parts.
D	Correct	Adds the qualitative and reader-and-task dimensions.

11. Answer D Concept 7

A school is reviewing a K-2 reading program. Its word-reading prompts say, "Look at the picture and think what would make sense." ~~The program has colorful books and a free app~~. Why is this a concern under the science of reading?

Target word: evaluate a resource **Decides:** Prompts rely on guessing rather than decoding.

A	Adjacent category	Does not address the word-reading concern.
B	Camouflage	Design is not the instructional problem.
C	Absolute language	Pictures support meaning, not word identification.
D	Correct	Three-cueing prompts conflict with decoding instruction.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A fifth grader's draft of a letter to the principal asking for a school garden lists ideas without reasons. ~~The student used a purple pen and wrote three pages~~. What is the best revision feedback?

Target word: revision vs. editing **Decides:** The problem is content for the audience and purpose.

A	Dropped element	Shortening drops the missing reasons problem.
B	Confusion set	That is editing, not revision.
C	Correct	Revision strengthens content for audience and purpose.
D	Camouflage	Appearance does not fix content.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The Simple View of Reading	Reading comprehension = decoding × language comprehension; if either is weak, comprehension suffers, so diagnose which one.	Treating every comprehension problem as a need for more comprehension strategies.	A student who understands text read aloud but not text read alone, or the reverse.
2	Scarborough's Reading Rope	Word-recognition strands (phonological awareness, decoding, sight recognition) become increasingly automatic; language-comprehension strands (background knowledge, vocabulary, language structures, verbal reasoning, literacy knowledge) become increasingly strategic.	Placing vocabulary or background knowledge in the word-recognition strands.	Classifying a reading skill into a strand.
3	Phonological awareness vs. phonics	Phonological awareness is oral work with sounds (no letters); phonics links sounds to letters. Awareness moves from larger units (words, syllables, onset-rime) to individual phonemes.	Calling a letter-sound activity phonological awareness.	Whether print is involved in the task.
4	Social vs. academic language	Conversational language (BICS) often develops in about 1–3 years; academic language (CALP) often takes about 5–7 years.	Assuming an English learner who chats fluently is ready for academic text without support.	A fluent-speaking English learner struggling with content reading.
5	Fluency: accuracy, rate, prosody	Words correct per minute = (words read – errors) ÷ minutes; accuracy = words correct ÷ words read; prosody is expression and phrasing.	Counting total words read as WCPM, or treating speed alone as fluency.	An oral reading record with words, errors, and time.
6	Text complexity	Judge text complexity with three parts: quantitative measures, qualitative features, and reader-and-task considerations.	Relying on a readability number alone.	Choosing a text for a grade or purpose.
7	Evaluating reading resources	Resources aligned with the science of reading teach students to decode words fully; they avoid prompts to guess words from pictures or context (three-cueing).	Choosing materials that prompt “look at the picture and guess.”	Word-reading prompts in a program being reviewed.
8	Purposeful writing process	Writing is recursive (plan, draft, revise, edit, publish) and shaped by audience and purpose; revision is about content, editing about conventions.	Treating revision as fixing spelling and punctuation.	Feedback on a draft or planning a writing task.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Literacy Curriculum is a comprehensive course that deepens an educator's knowledge of language acquisition and progressively complex concepts and skills surrounding literacy. This course explores critical elements of the science of reading and writing, including applying key theories and research used to support the development of literacy, evaluating diverse resources, and utilizing purposeful oral, written, and digital communication in elementary curriculum. Candidates delve into the foundational aspects of literacy, including phonological awareness, phonics, word analysis, fluency, and comprehension, while also gaining insights into how these elements shape and influence literacy development. This dynamic course empowers educators to create a solid foundation for students' literacy skills and a lifelong love of reading and writing within various learning environments.